

## Methods

The allocation sequence was generated by an independent statistician using a computer-based random-number generator. <sup>[17a]</sup>

Allocation was concealed using sequentially numbered, opaque, sealed envelopes. <sup>[18]</sup>

## Appendix: verbatim compliance excerpts

This appendix is not part of the official CONSORT grid (which only has a page-number column) — it demonstrates excerpt-of, re-emitting the real manuscript wording next to each item, for a journal that additionally wants verbatim quotes.

**Item 17a** (Sequence generation): **p. 1** — “The allocation sequence was generated by an independent statistician using a computer-based random-number generator.”

**Item 18** (Allocation concealment mechanism): **p. 1** — “Allocation was concealed using sequentially numbered, opaque, sealed envelopes.”

**Item 19** (Implementation) — never checked in this manuscript, default on-empty: none renders nothing between the colon and the period: .

**Item 20a** (Blinding) — never checked either, but with an explicit fallback: *(not reported)*.